



Optional refresher: Alex and the importance of data ethics

Hi, I'm Alex. I'm a research scientist at Google. My team is called the Ethical AI Team. We're a group of folks that really are concerned not only about how AI, the technology operates, but how it interacts with society and how it might help or harm marginalized communities. So when we talk about data ethics, we think about, What is the good and right way of using data? What are going to be ways that are going to be uses of data that are going to be beneficial to people? When it comes to data ethics it's not just about minimizing harm, but it's actually this concept of beneficence. How do we actually improve the lives of people by using data? When we think about data ethics we're thinking about who's collecting the data? Why are they collecting it? How are they collecting it? And for what purpose? Because of the way that organizations have imperatives to make money, or to report to somebody, or provide some analysis, we also have to keep strongly in mind how this is actually going to benefit people at the end of the day. Are the people represented in this data going to be benefited by this? I think that's the thing you never want to lose sight of as a data scientist or a data analyst. I think aspiring data analysts need to keep in mind that a lot of the data that you're going to encounter is data that comes from people. So at the end of the day, data are people. And you want to have a responsibility to those people that are represented in those data. Second, is thinking about how to keep aspects of their data protected and private.

We don't want to go through our practice thinking about data **instances** as something we can just throw on the web. No, there needs to be **considerations** about how to keep that information and likenesses, like their images, or their voices or their text. **How do we keep that private?** **We also need to think about how we can have mechanisms of giving users and giving consumers more control over their data.** It's not going to be sufficient just to say, we collected all this data and trust us with all these data, but we need to ensure that there's **actionable** ways in which people can **consent** to giving those data and ways that they can ask for it to be **revoked** or removed. Data's growing, and at the same time, we need to empower people to have control over their own data. The future is that data is always growing. We haven't seen any kind of evidence that data is actually **shrinking**. And with the knowledge that data's growing, these issues become more and more **piqued** and more and more important to think about.